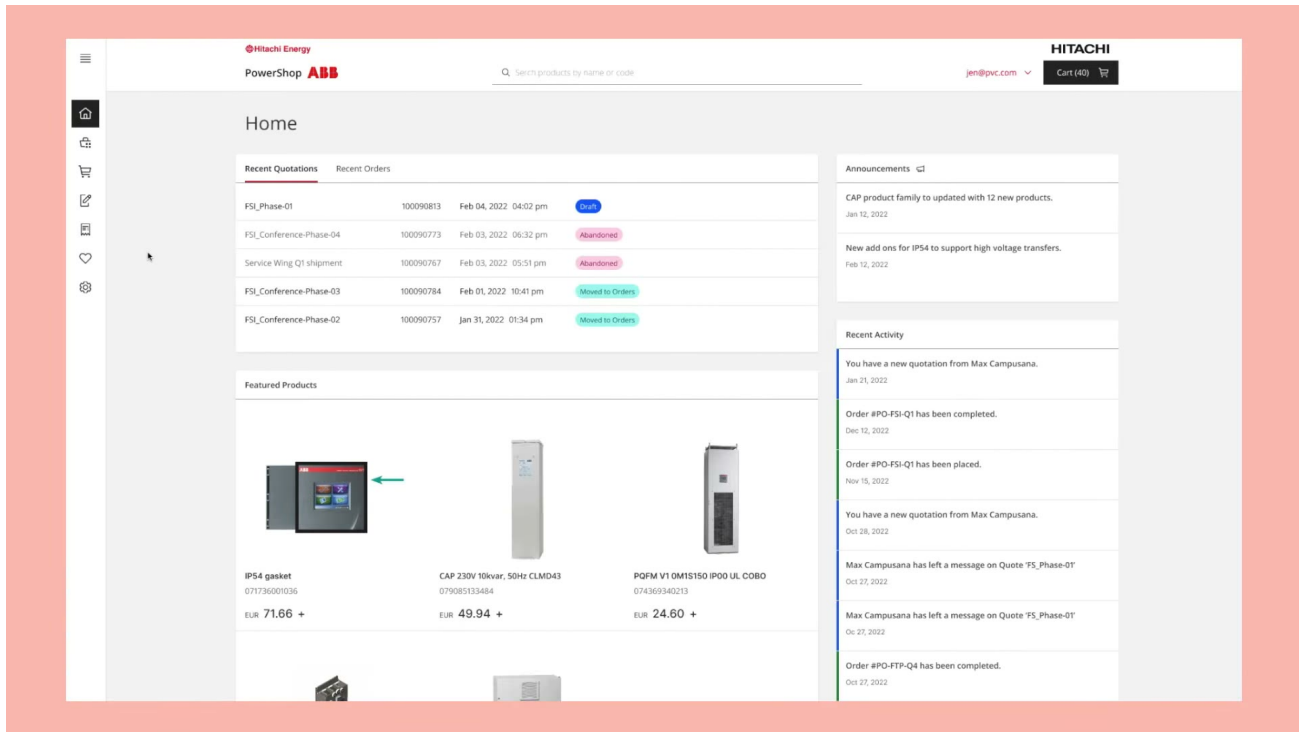


Designing a B2B buying experience for Hitachi's Sales Partners

Source: /work/hitachi-energy/



Video poster | Alt text: Designing a B2B buying experience for Hitachi's Sales Partners | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/video/partner-commerce-overview.webm

Sales partners purchase industrial equipment from Hitachi Energy in bulk to later sell to customers on demand and fulfill orders.

I led the design of the improved storefront partner portal, including identifying and digitizing parts of the quotation process that remained offline.

Stakeholder: Hitachi Energy

Skills: Discovery User Experience Design Journey Mapping

Year: 2021-22 (6 months)

Role: Senior Designer · Team

The team

- Vinodh Kumar Product Manager
- Joseph Xavier Sr. Engineering Manager
- Baljinder Kaur Lead Frontend Engineer

Context

A partner might buy dozens of configurable products for a customer tender. Price depended on the order, delivery terms, compatible components, and what a factory could fulfill.

That made the transaction a collaboration between two stakeholders: a sales partner assembling the order and a Hitachi account manager coordinating factories, engineers, and commercial terms.



Jen Williams

Sales Partner

*internally referred as **buyers / users / customers.***

Key Responsibility (within our context):

I make purchases from Hitachi to fulfill tenders and future orders for end customers.



Max Campusana

Account Manager

*internally referred as **sales representative.***

Key Responsibility (within our context):

Coordinate with factories, engineers, and partners to make additional sales.

Image | Alt text: Sales partner and Hitachi account manager with their responsibilities | Caption: The two sides of the experience: a sales partner purchasing for an end customer, and a Hitachi account manager coordinating the people and conditions needed to fulfill it. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/partner-account-team.png

Mapping the Partner Journey

I collaborated with business partners in Germany, India, Thailand, and Australia while learning the configuration, pricing, and quotation process.

The journey map compared what partners were trying to accomplish with the touchpoints, constraints, and account-team activity behind each step. The storefront covered browsing and configuration, then disappeared as soon as the relationship work began.

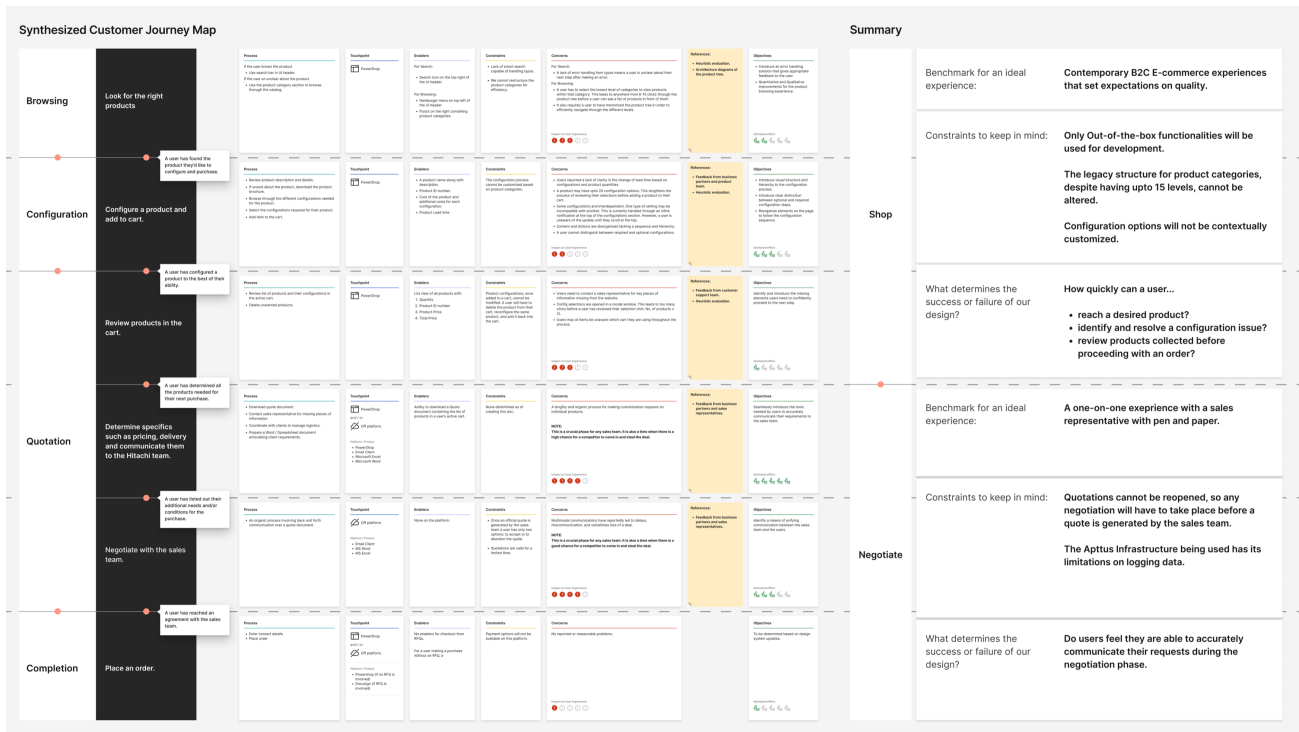


Image | Alt text: Synthesized journey from product browsing through order completion | Caption: The partner journey put browsing, configuration, quotation, and negotiation in one view, including the constraints and off-platform work in each phase. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/journey-map.png

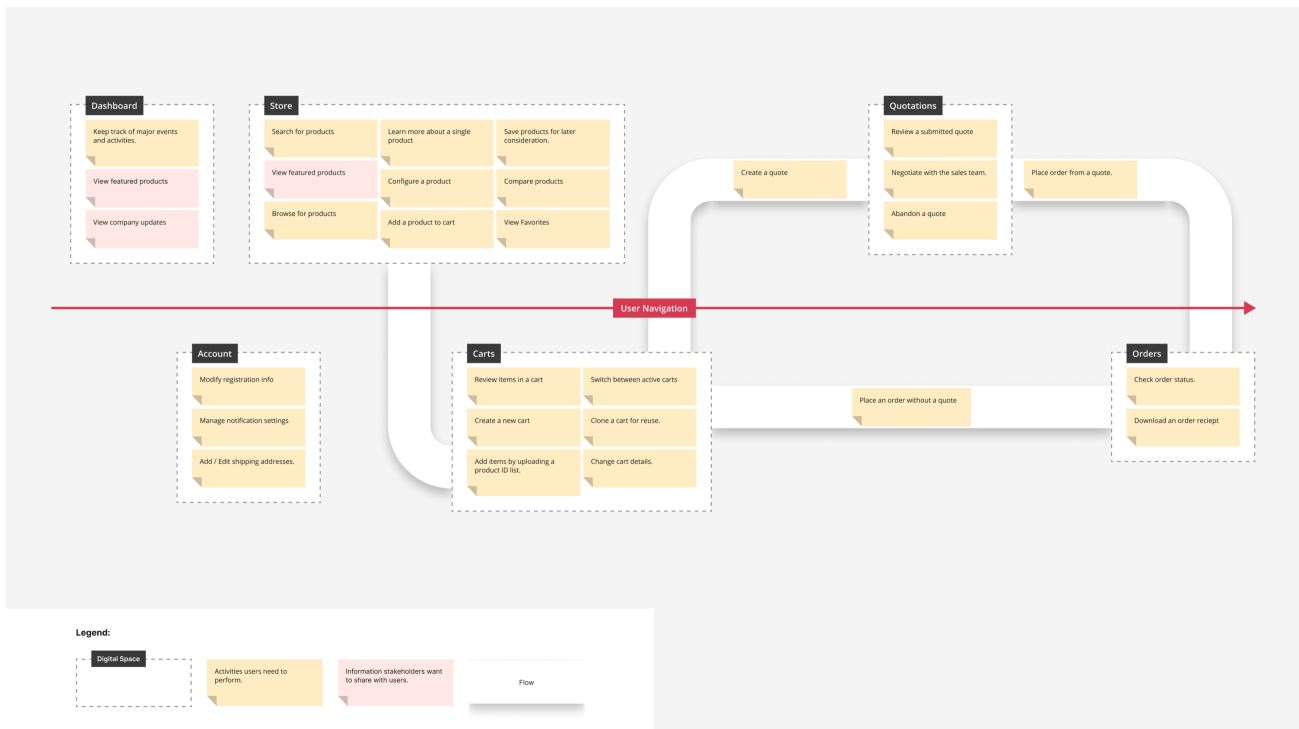


Image | Alt text: Map of platform spaces and activities | Caption: I translated the journey into digital spaces and flows so product and engineering could see where each activity belonged and where the quotation loop needed to reconnect. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/platform-space-map.png

Defining the Quotation Experience

The roadmap proposed a quote button and an open text field. A partner could begin a request online, but every meaningful exchange after that would still happen offline.

A partial solution risked making the process harder to follow: the platform would show that a quote had started without showing what had changed, who was waiting, or whether the order was ready to place.

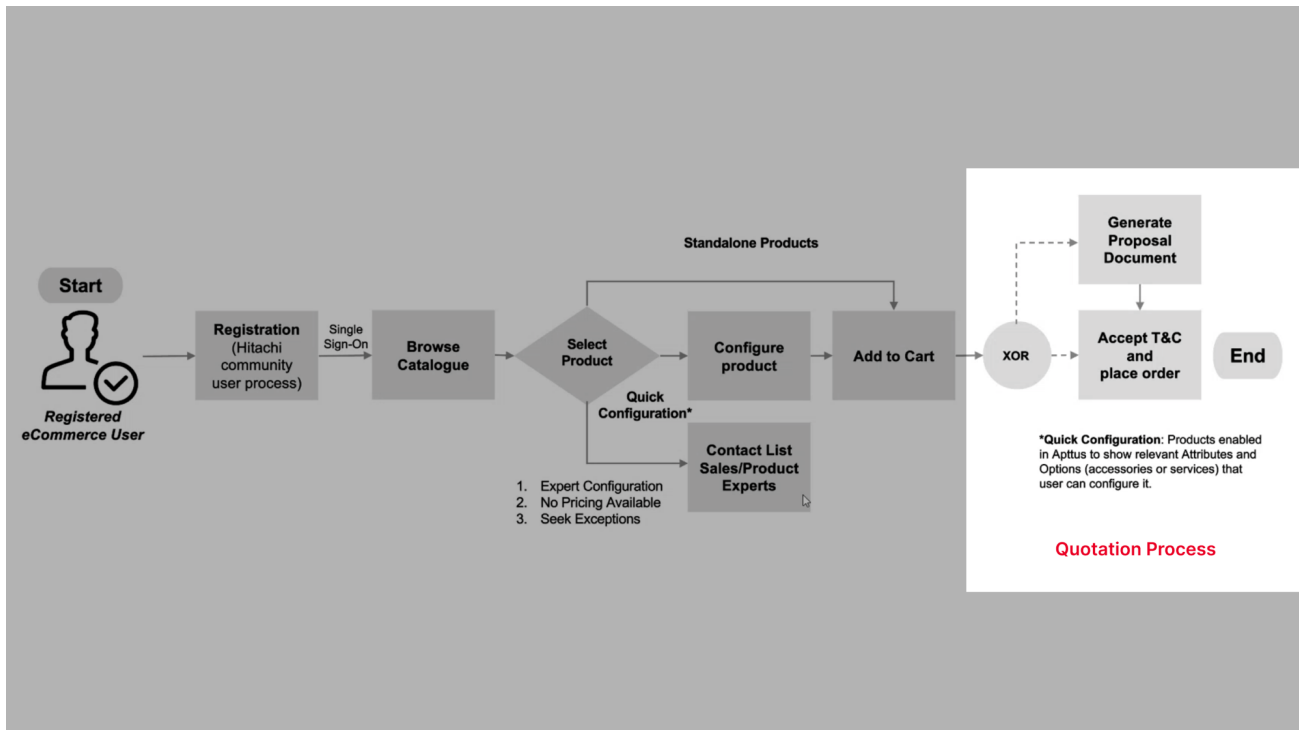


Image | Alt text: Original flow ending at proposal generation | Caption: The original plan digitized the trigger, then handed quotation and negotiation back to offline channels. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/original-quotation-boundary.png

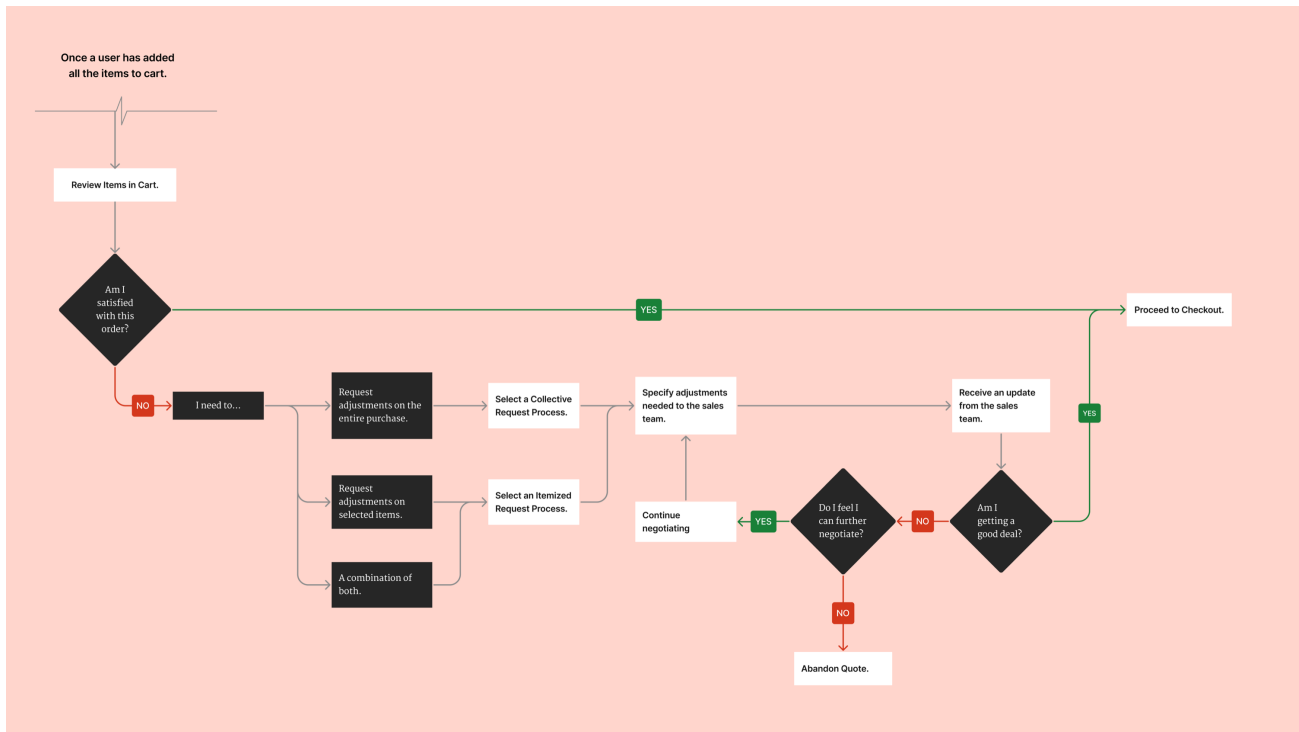


Image | Alt text: Updated end-to-end quotation flow | Caption: The revised flow kept quote creation, account-team review, partner negotiation, approval, and order placement connected inside the product. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/updated-quotation-flow.png

Designing the Quotation Conversation

I separated quotation exchanges into structured requests, such as discounts or delivery changes, and the less predictable negotiation that followed. Comparable information needed structure, while counteroffers, explanations, attachments, and exceptions needed room for conversation.

The prototypes showed that a request form alone would preserve the email handoff, so I used them to make the case for delaying release and bringing the full quotation exchange into the portal. Product, engineering, and business leadership agreed; I kept item-level quotation in scope and cut batch actions and product recommendations to avoid another delay.

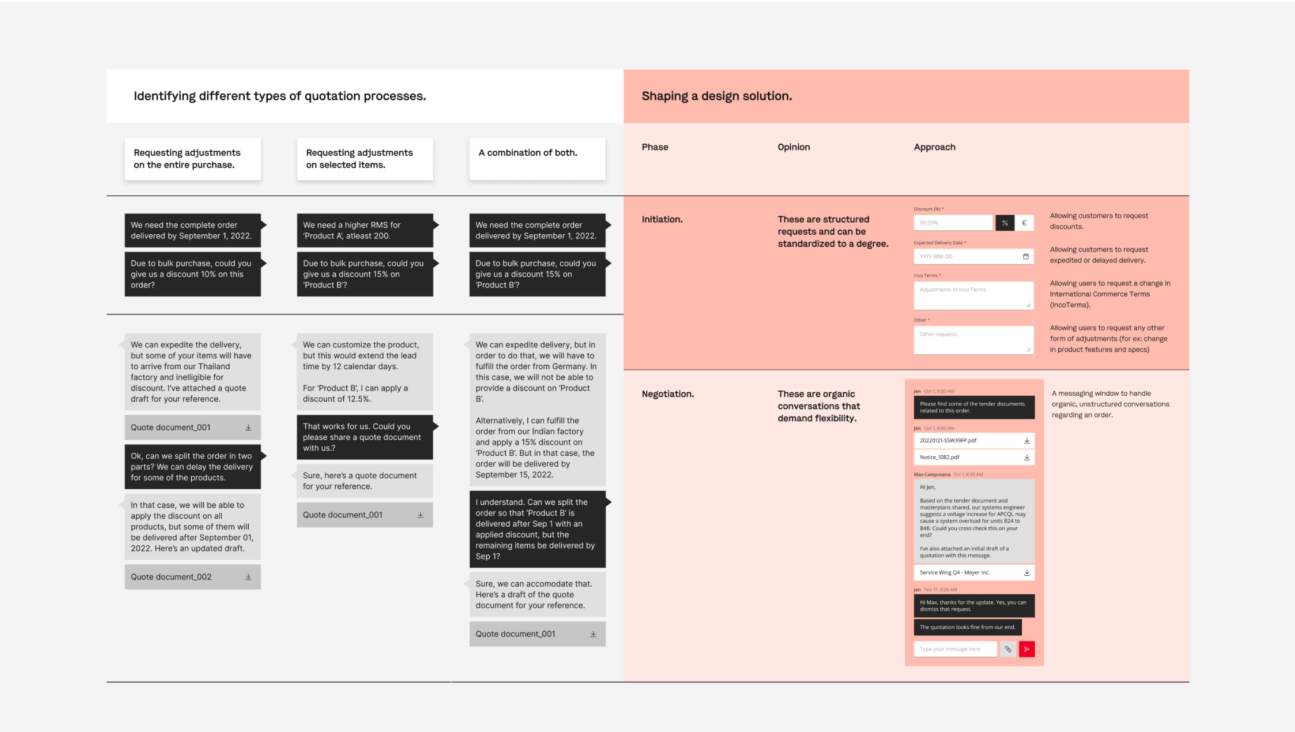


Image | Alt text: Quotation conversations translated into structured and flexible interaction patterns | Caption: Conversation analysis separated a quote's structured initiation from the flexible negotiation that followed, giving each a different interaction model. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/quotation-conversation-model.png



Request for Quote

Product Name	Product Code	Lead Time	Quantity	Total	Adjustment Requests		
Product 01	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 02	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 03	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 04	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 05	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 06	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 07	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 08	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 09	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	
Product 10	OQJWND08	21 Calendar Days	10	EUR 123,456		Inco Terms	

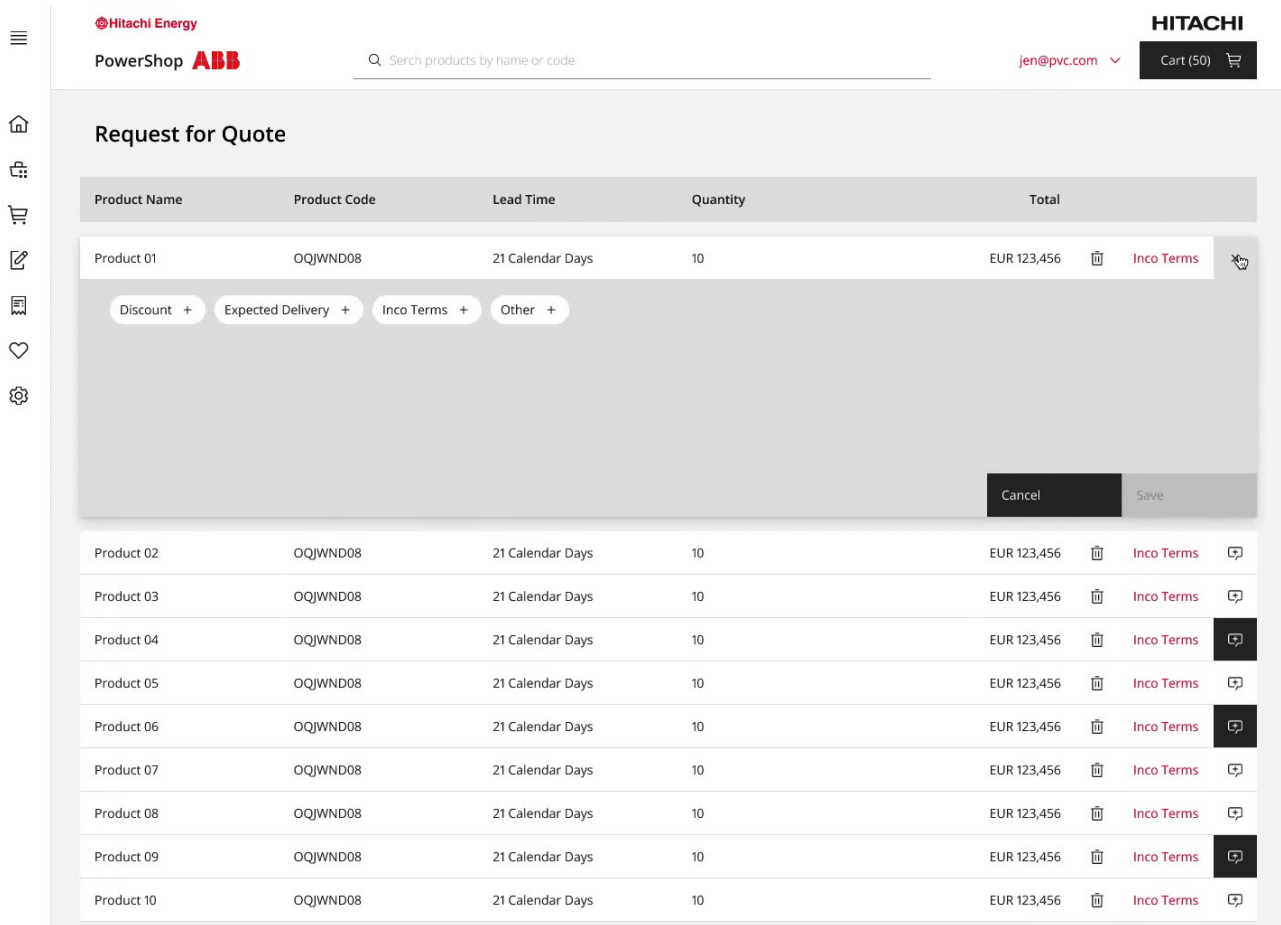
Product 02

Product 06

Product 07

Product 10

Video poster | Alt text: Inline item-level quote adjustment prototype | Caption: Concept 01: item-level adjustment requests stayed close to the product rows they changed. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/video/quotation-concept-inline.webm



Video poster | Alt text: Quote adjustment side-panel prototype | Caption: Concept 02: a persistent panel made it easier to move between several adjusted items in a large order. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/video/quotation-concept-panel.webm

Designing Item-Level Negotiation

Bulk orders made a single quote-level form too blunt. A partner might request a delivery change on one item, a discount on another, and accept the remaining products as quoted.

I designed a flexible product tile that could hold configurations, add-ons, lead time, requested changes, and account-team responses without sending people through a stack of panels.

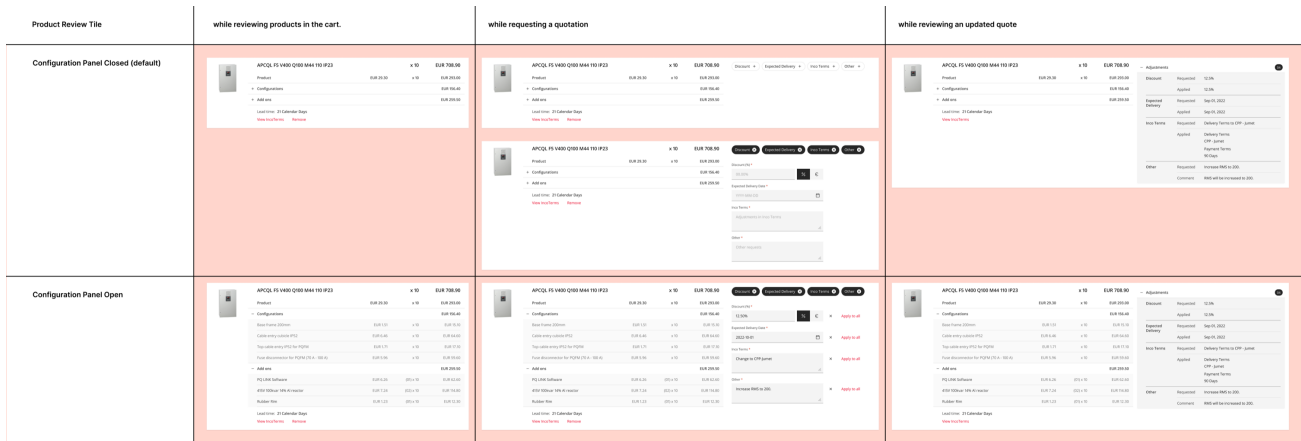
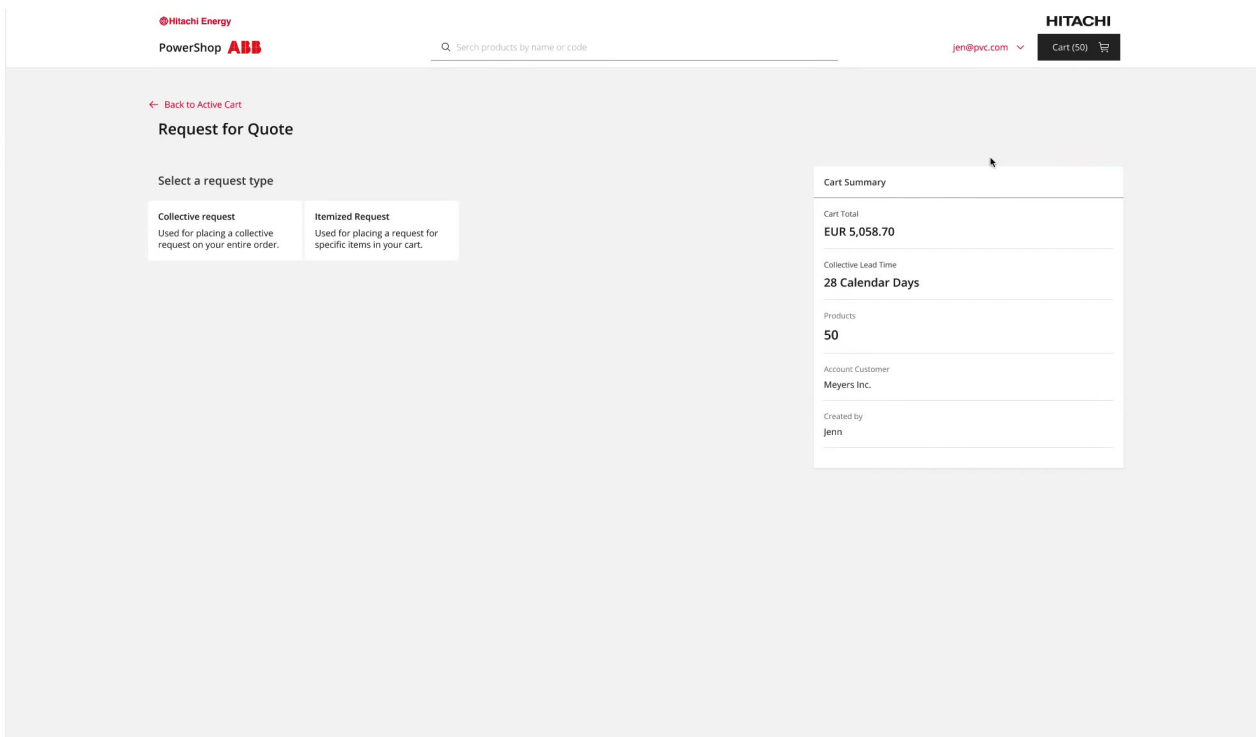


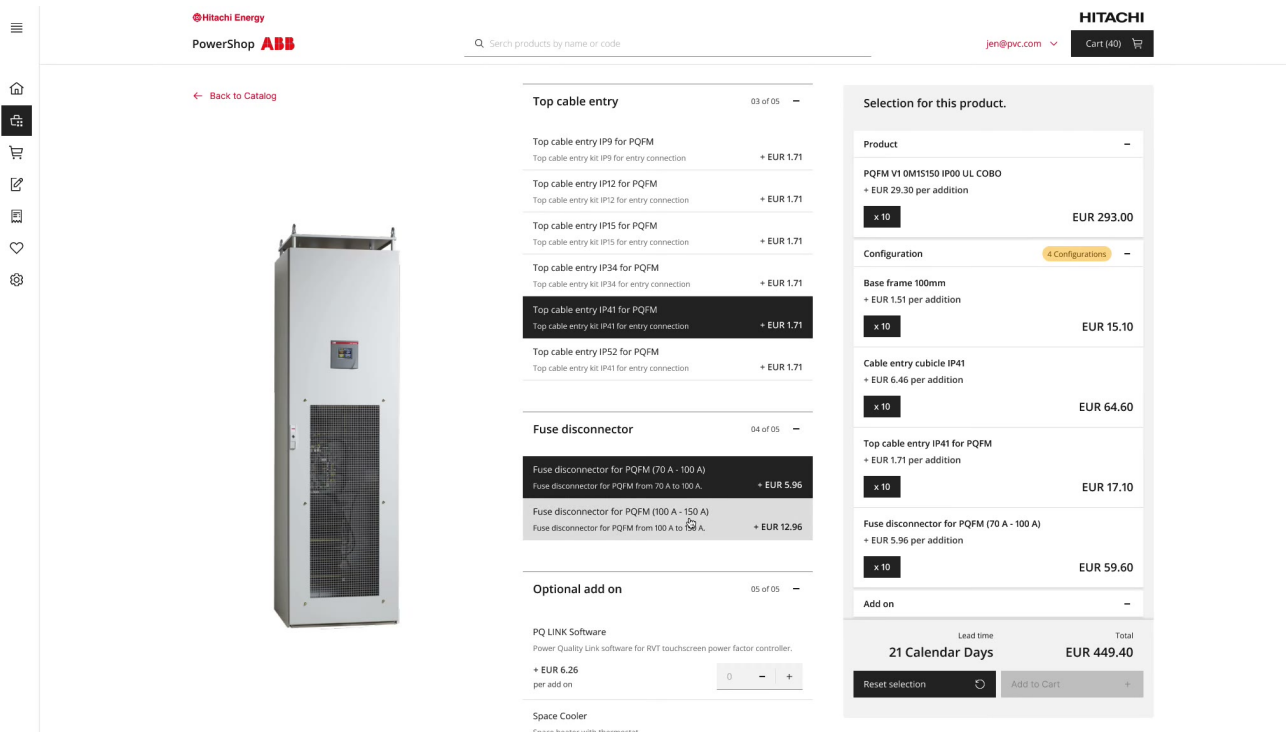
Image | Alt text: Product tile across cart, quote request, and updated quote states | Caption: The product tile became the shared unit across cart review, request creation, and the account team's revised quote. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/flexible-product-tile.png



Video poster | Alt text: Itemized quotation workflow | Caption: The itemized flow let partners apply requests to individual products while retaining a readable view of the full order. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/video/itemized-quotation-flow.webm

Designing Configuration Dependencies

The same component model also had to carry configuration dependencies. When one selection required another component, the interface explained the relationship in context and blocked an invalid cart state.



Video poster | Alt text: Product configuration dependency and error handling | Caption: Configuration feedback showed the required add-on beside the affected selection, keeping recovery inside the product-building flow. | Source asset: /assets/hitachi/video/configuration-error-handling.webm

Impact

Nine to twelve months after launch, the business team reported two outcomes: deals were closing about three weeks sooner, and active opportunities went quiet less often.

Keeping each request, response, and pending decision in one place helped partners and account teams see what was holding up a deal and keep it moving.

What I Learned

The problem was widely recognized, but it did not reach the roadmap until the prototype made a solution tangible.

When I raised the gaps in the quotation process with business partners, I met very little resistance because they already recognized the problem, but the people responsible for the process had not raised it without a solution to propose. Once the prototype showed how quotation could work inside the platform, the team could evaluate something concrete and acknowledge the problem as work that belonged on the roadmap.